

Innovating successfully

Any innovation project involves a degree of risk—there is always the chance that it might fail. It is important for any organization undertaking innovation to be aware of the factors that make innovations more likely to succeed, and to be able to identify those that are likely to fail.

Identifying successful innovations

The history of product and process innovations is littered with examples of apparently good ideas that failed—in some cases with spectacular consequences. Most organizations would own up to having problems with making innovation happen, including a fair proportion of ideas that are never realized, and new initiatives that flop more or less embarrassingly. However, a great deal of research has gone into identifying the key areas on which organizations can focus to promote successful innovation. It might not be possible to guarantee success every time, but paying attention to the key aspects can stack the deck in your favor. Remember, innovation doesn't happen by accident, but by careful planning.



CASE STUDY

Long-term innovation culture

3M is a world-class product innovator. Best known for products like Post-it notes and Scotch tape, it has a history of innovation success in diverse fields: computer disks and tape, industrial coatings and abrasives, medical supplies, and office products. It began in 1901 as the Minnesota Mining and

Manufacturing Corporation—and its first attempts at establishing the business were not successful. But the company persisted, and built a business that today sets a goal of getting 30 percent of its revenues from products introduced in the past three years. It has spent a 100 years refining its approach to innovation—and continues to succeed in doing so.